Define What Your MVP Must Teach You

An MVP should answer an important question—not just deliver a smaller product.

An MVP is both a focused user experience and a learning opportunity. Before deciding what to build, identify the uncertainty that could materially change your product direction, scope or investment. Then design the smallest coherent experience that can produce useful evidence about it.

Start with a decision, not a feature

1 · NAME THE DECISION

What decision will you make after the MVP? For example: continue, change the target user, revise the value proposition, simplify scope or stop.

2 · IDENTIFY THE UNCERTAINTY

Which assumption makes that decision difficult today? Focus on something consequential—not merely something interesting.

3 · DEFINE THE EVIDENCE

What would you need to observe, hear or measure to become more confident—or to change your mind?

4 · DESIGN A LEARNING EXPERIENCE

What is the smallest coherent user journey or test that could produce that evidence without pretending the result proves more than it does?

A useful learning question

“We need to learn whether [specific user] can or will [meaningful behavior or outcome] in [context], because this will inform [product decision]. We will look for [observable signal] and consider [what would challenge the hypothesis].”

Important

A metric is not automatically a learning goal. Choose measures only when they help answer a decision-relevant question. Record assumptions and limits explicitly.

Worksheet · Choose the learning goal

Complete the fields before fixing MVP scope. If you do not know an answer, write it as an open question rather than guessing.

1. What product decision must this MVP inform?

2. Which assumption most affects that decision?

3. Which user and context does the assumption concern?

4. Write the hypothesis in a specific, challengeable form.

5. What evidence exists now—and what is still only assumed?

Prioritize the learning question

Decision impact	If the assumption is wrong, would the product direction, MVP scope or investment change?
Current uncertainty	How limited, indirect or contradictory is the evidence?
Learnability	Can a small, realistic test produce useful information in time?

Worksheet · Design the learning experience

Design a test that can challenge the hypothesis, not just collect supportive feedback. Keep the test proportionate to the decision and the risks.

6. The specific learning question we need to answer is…

7. What is the smallest useful test or user journey?

8. Who or what will be observed, and in which context?

9. What observable signal would support the hypothesis?

10. What result would weaken or challenge the hypothesis?

11. What will this test not be able to tell us?

12. How could different results change the product decision?

Review · Is the MVP designed to teach?

Use this checklist before treating the learning plan as ready. A good plan connects uncertainty, evidence and a decision; it does not guarantee a particular result.

Learning plan quality check

- [ ] The learning question is linked to a specific product decision.
- [ ] The hypothesis concerns a defined user, context or meaningful behavior.
- [ ] The hypothesis could be weakened or disproved by plausible evidence.
- [ ] The test is small enough to run but coherent enough to observe meaningful behavior.
- [ ] The signal is observable and relevant to the question.
- [ ] Both supportive and disconfirming results are considered.
- [ ] The limitations of the test and evidence are recorded.
- [ ] The plan does not claim to prove market demand or product success from weak evidence.
- [ ] The result will lead to a named next decision or follow-up question.

After the test

What happened? Record observations separately from interpretation.

What did we learn, and what remains uncertain?

What will we continue, change, test next or stop?

Learning loop

Evidence → Learning → Revised Hypothesis → Product Change